NAME: _____ CLASS: _____ TEACHER: _____

KEY TOPIC 3 CHRONOLOGICAL ENQUIRY SEQUENCE • 1954–1968

Key Topic 3: US Involvement in the Vietnam War, 1954–68

Domino Theory, Diem Regime, Gulf of Tonkin, Rolling Thunder & The Tet Offensive



HISTORICAL PRIMARY RECORD • 1966

US Army "Huey" Combat Assault Landing in South Vietnam, 1966

Bell UH-1D Iroquois helicopters land US infantry into a forward jungle clearing, demonstrating the air mobility and search-and-destroy doctrine central to General Westmoreland's strategy.

PEARSON EDEXCEL OPTION 33 • KEY TOPIC 3 CONTENT OFFICIAL SPECIFICATION DIRECTORY

1 Reasons for US Involvement in the Conflict in Vietnam, 1954–63

- Reasons for greater US involvement under Eisenhower, including the **domino theory** and weaknesses of the Diem government.
- Greater involvement under Kennedy, including the overthrow of Diem and the Strategic Hamlet Program.

2 Escalation of the Conflict Under Johnson

- Reasons for the escalation of the conflict and increased US involvement in Vietnam, including the increasing threat of the Vietcong and the **Gulf of Tonkin** incident (1964).

3 The Nature of the Conflict in Vietnam, 1964–68

- The guerrilla tactics used by the Vietcong.
- The methods used by the USA, including **Search and Destroy**, **Operation Rolling Thunder** and chemical weapons.
- The key features and significance of the Tet Offensive, 1968.

4 Changes Under Nixon, 1969–73

- The key features of **Vietnamisation**. Reasons for its failure.
- The Nixon Doctrine and the withdrawal of US troops.
- Attacks on Cambodia (1970) and Laos (1971), and the bombing of North Vietnam (1972).

Domino Theory, Diem Regime, Vietcong & Johnson's Escalation

REVISION MIND-MAP CANVAS: At the end of each lesson, use the app's *Consolidate Station* to retrieve your keywords and branch out your mind-map across the open page (Cold War Fears & Saigon Crisis to the left • Military Escalation to the right).

◂ DIEN BIEN PHU & DOMINOES

1954–56 Geneva Accords & Diem Regime (KT 3.1)

17TH SPLIT & CANCELLED VOTE ▸

◂ NLF FORMED & GREEN BERETS

1960–63 Vietcong & Strategic Hamlets (KT 3.1)

BUDDHIST CRISIS & DIEM COUP ▸

◂ USS MADDOX TORPEDO CLAIM

AUG 1964 Gulf of Tonkin Resolution (KT 3.2)

CONGRESSIONAL BLANK CHEQUE ▸

◂ PLEIKU RAID & AIR BOMBING

FEB–MAR 1965 Rolling Thunder & Da Nang (KT 3.2)

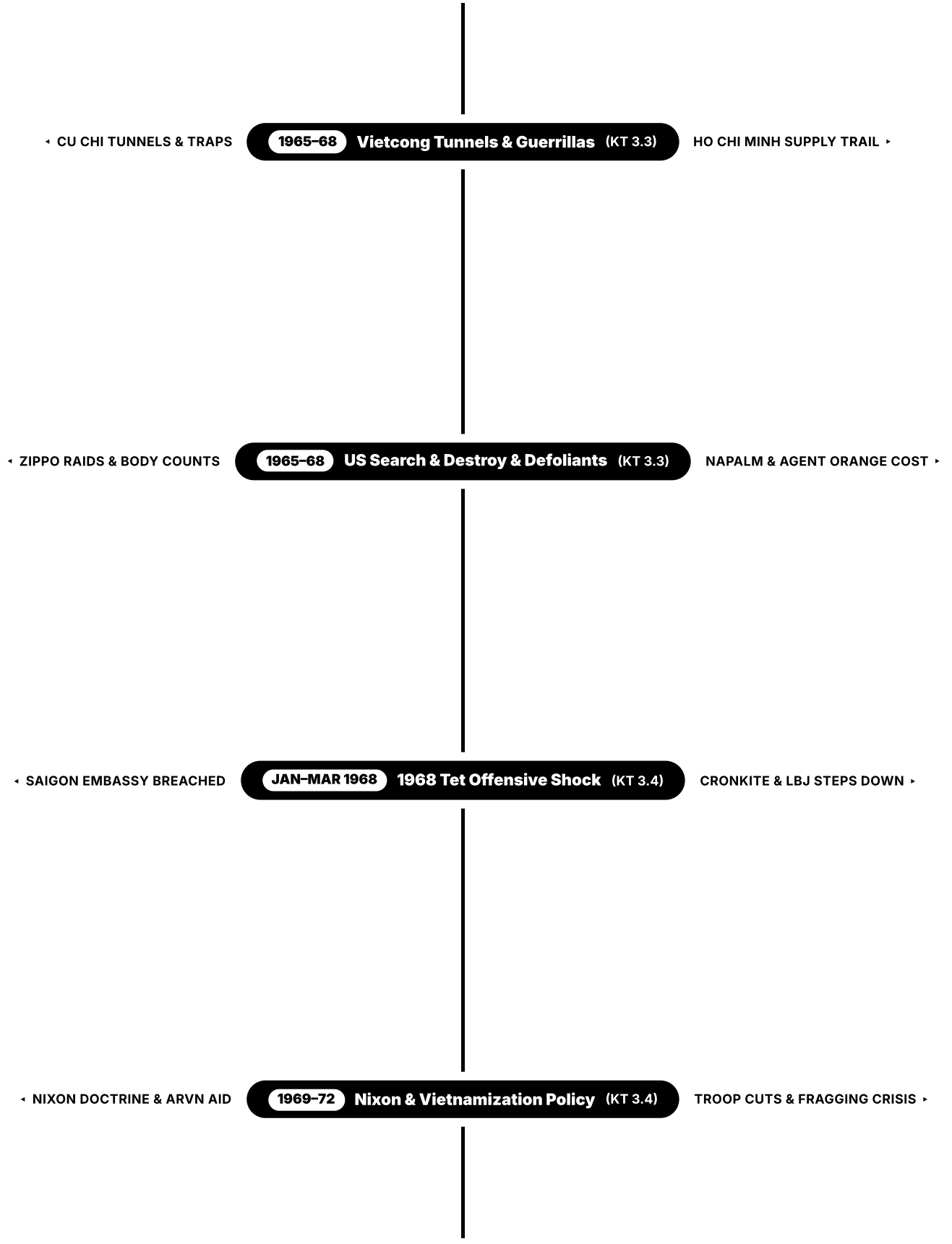
3,500 MARINES & US DRAFT ▸

SPECIFICATION SPINE CONTINUES TO GUERRILLA WAR, TET & NIXON (PAGE 3) ➔

"Domino Theory (1954): Eisenhower warned that if Indochina fell to communism, Southeast Asia would collapse like dominoes."

Guerrilla vs Conventional Tactics, Tet Offensive & Vietnamization

REVISION MIND-MAP CANVAS: At the end of each lesson, use the app's *Consolidate Station* to retrieve your keywords and branch out your mind-map across the open page (Tactics & Surprise Assaults to the left • Political Fallout & Withdrawal to the right).



Why did the US support the unpopular government of Ngo Dinh Diem in South Vietnam?

AUDIO • QUIZ

1 • Why did the French defeat at Dien Bien Phu lead to the temporary partition of Vietnam at the 17th Parallel?

- Battle of Dien Bien Phu
- French colonial collapse
- 17th parallel partition

2 • Why did Ngo Dinh Diem cancel the 1956 nationwide reunification elections with American support?

- President Dwight Eisenhower
- Domino theory concept
- SEATO alliance formed

3 • How did Diem's repressive policies in South Vietnam lead directly to the formation of the Vietcong in 1960?

- Ngo Dinh Diem regime
- Refusal of nationwide elections
- Strategic hamlets resentment

4 • Why did the Strategic Hamlet Program and the Buddhist Crisis fatally undermine South Vietnamese support fo...

- President John F. Kennedy
- Green Beret advisers (16,000)
- Buddhist monk self-immolations

5 • How did the 1963 military coup and assassination of Diem leave the United States trapped in South Vietnam?

- South Vietnamese military coup
- Diem assassinated (Nov 1963)
- Saigon political instability

"Ngo Dinh Diem: US-backed Catholic dictator in Saigon who cancelled elections and brutally repressed the Buddhist majority."

Question 2: Explain Why [12 marks • 15 mins] EDEXCEL PAPER 3

Score: [/ 12]

Explain why the United States became increasingly involved in Vietnam between 1954 and 1963. [12 marks]

You may use in your answer: • The Domino Theory and the Cold War containment policy • US support for Ngo Dinh Diem and the growth of the Vietcong *(You must also use information of your own.)*

ANALYTICAL CONNECTIVES: *One decisive reason was that... • For example, this meant that... • This directly triggered... • Therefore, this was critical because... • On the other hand, another factor was... • Consequently, the ultimate result was...*

Write your response in the space provided below:

(Response continues on Page 6)

MIND-MAP MISSION Turn to Page 2 (Key Topic 3.1). Use the Consolidate Station keywords to branch out 'Geneva Accords & Diem Regime' and 'Vietcong & Strategic Hamlets' with Domino Theory and the 1963 Saigon coup. [ ] Done

QUESTION 1 PRACTICE **INFERENCE FROM SOURCE A** **4 MARKS • 5 MINS** **Score: [/ 4]**

Give two things you can infer from Source A about American geopolitical fears regarding the spread of communism in Southeast Asia (1954). [4 marks]

SOURCE A *President Dwight D. Eisenhower, The President's News Conference (7 April 1954), Public Papers of the Presidents*

You have, of course, both the specific and the general when you talk about such things. First of all, you have the specific value of a locality in its production of materials that the world needs, like rubber and ti...

(i) What I can infer: *[1 mark]*

Details in SOURCE A that tell me this: *[1 mark]*

(ii) What I can infer: *[1 mark]*

Details in SOURCE A that tell me this: *[1 mark]*

Why did the US send combat troops to Vietnam after the Gulf of Tonkin incident?

AUDIO • QUIZ

1 • Why did the military collapse of the ARVN in 1963–64 convince US leaders that direct intervention was unavoida...

- Saigon military instability
- Chronic ARVN desertions
- Vietcong rural expansion

2 • What occurred during the August 1964 Gulf of Tonkin incident, and how did Johnson use it politically?

- USS Maddox patrol
- Gulf of Tonkin incident
- Disputed second torpedo attack

3 • Why was the Gulf of Tonkin Resolution described by critics as a 'blank check' for presidential war-making?

- Gulf of Tonkin Resolution
- Congress 'blank check'
- Presidential war powers

4 • What were the strategic objectives of Operation Rolling Thunder, and why did it fail to halt northern infiltration?

- Vietcong raid on Pleiku
- Eight US soldiers killed
- Operation Rolling Thunder launched

5 • How did the landing of 3,500 Marines at Da Nang in March 1965 mark the permanent Americanization of the wa...

- Da Nang beach landing
- 3,500 US Marines arrive
- General Westmoreland escalation

Question 2: Explain Why [12 marks • 15 mins] EDEXCEL PAPER 3

Score: [/ 12]

Explain why US military involvement in Vietnam escalated under President Johnson between 1964 and 1965. [12 marks]

You may use in your answer: • The Gulf of Tonkin incident (August 1964) • The attack on the US base at Pleiku (February 1965) ***(You must also use information of your own.)***

ANALYTICAL CONNECTIVES: *One decisive reason was that... • For example, this meant that... • This directly triggered... • Therefore, this was critical because... • On the other hand, another factor was... • Consequently, the ultimate result was...*

Write your response in the space provided below: *(Response continues on Page 9)*

MIND-MAP MISSION Turn to Page 2 (Key Topic 3.2). Use the Consolidate Station keywords to branch out 'Gulf of Tonkin Resolution' and 'Rolling Thunder & Da Nang' with USS Maddox and US combat escalation. [ ] Done

QUESTION 1 PRACTICE **INFERENCE FROM SOURCE A** **4 MARKS • 5 MINS** **Score: [/ 4]**

Give two things you can infer from Source A about the deployment of US Marines to Vietnam in March 1965. [4 marks]

SOURCE A *Commander, Task Group 72.1 (USS Maddox) to Commander Seventh Fleet, Flash Precedence Cable (4 August 1964)*

Review of action makes many reported contacts and torpedoes fired appear doubtful. Freak weather effects on radar and overeager sonarmen may have accounted for many reports. No actual visual sightings by Maddox. Sug...

(i) What I can infer: *[1 mark]*

Details in SOURCE A that tell me this: *[1 mark]*

(ii) What I can infer: *[1 mark]*

Details in SOURCE A that tell me this: *[1 mark]*

Why did US military tactics (like bombing and search & destroy) fail to defeat the Vietcong?

AUDIO • QUIZ

1 • How did the Vietcong tactic of 'hanging onto the belts' neutralize superior American firepower and technology?

- General Vo Nguyen Giap strategy
- 'Hanging on US belt buckles'
- Vanishing into peasant villages

2 • Why did the Cu Chi tunnel complex and deadly booby traps severely undermine American military morale?

- Cu Chi 250km tunnel networks
- Punji sticks & booby traps
- Subterranean supply rooms

3 • How did the Ho Chi Minh Trail enable North Vietnam to sustain the southern insurgency despite continuous US...

- Ho Chi Minh Trail network
- Laos & Cambodia border routes
- Soviet & Chinese arms pipeline

4 • Why did the use of chemical defoliants like Agent Orange and napalm prove counterproductive for US military ...

- Operation Ranch Hand
- Agent Orange chemical defoliant
- Napalm burning jelly

5 • How did Search and Destroy operations fail to distinguish between civilian peasants and Vietcong fighters?

- Helicopter air mobility
- 'Zippo' village burns
- Body-count measurement failure

"Tonkin Gulf Resolution: Congress granted President Johnson a blank cheque to take 'all necessary measures' in Vietnam."

Question 2: Explain Why [12 marks • 15 mins] EDEXCEL PAPER 3

Score: [/ 12]

Explain why US military tactics failed to defeat the Vietcong between 1965 and 1968. [12 marks]

You may use in your answer:
- Vietcong guerrilla tactics and underground tunnel networks
- US Search and Destroy missions and chemical defoliants (Agent Orange)

(You must also use information of your own.)

ANALYTICAL CONNECTIVES: *One decisive reason was that... • For example, this meant that... • This directly triggered... • Therefore, this was critical because... • On the other hand, another factor was... • Consequently, the ultimate result was...*

Write your response in the space provided below:

(Response continues on Page 12)

MIND-MAP MISSION Turn to Page 3 (Key Topic 3.3). Use the Consolidate Station keywords to branch out 'Vietcong Tunnels & Guerrillas' and 'US Search & Destroy & Defoliants' with Ho Chi Minh Trail and Agent Orange. [ ] Done

QUESTION 1 PRACTICE **INFERENCE FROM SOURCE A** **4 MARKS • 5 MINS** **Score: [/ 4]**

Give two things you can infer from Source A about the role of helicopters in US combat operations in Vietnam. [4 marks]

SOURCE A *MACV Combined Intelligence Center, Exploitation of Enemy Facilities Section*

Contemporary archival extract.

(i) What I can infer: *[1 mark]*

Details in SOURCE A that tell me this: *[1 mark]*

(ii) What I can infer: *[1 mark]*

Details in SOURCE A that tell me this: *[1 mark]*

What was Nixon's 'Vietnamization' policy, and did it achieve peace with honour?

AUDIO • QUIZ

1 • Why did the 1968 Tet Offensive shatter American government claims that the war in Vietnam was nearly won?

- Tet Offensive surprise assault
- US Embassy Saigon breached
- Military defeat for Vietcong

2 • How did Walter Cronkite's television broadcast deepen the public 'credibility gap' regarding the Vietnam War?

- Walter Cronkite CBS broadcast
- 'Mired in stalemate'
- Widening credibility gap

3 • Why did the political fallout from the Tet Offensive force President Johnson to withdraw from the 1968 preside...

- LBJ television address
- Bombing halt north 20th
- Withdrawal from 1968 election

4 • What were the core goals and contradictions of President Nixon's policy of 'Vietnamization'?

- Richard Nixon election
- Vietnamization doctrine
- ARVN army expansion

5 • How did phased troop withdrawals under Vietnamization affect the discipline and morale of remaining US forc...

- Phased US troop withdrawals
- GI morale crisis & 'fragging'
- Substance abuse in ranks

Question 2: Explain Why [12 marks • 15 mins] EDEXCEL PAPER 3

Score: [/ 12]

Explain why the Tet Offensive of January 1968 was a decisive turning point in the Vietnam War. [12 marks]

You may use in your answer:
- The military outcome for the Vietcong and US forces
- The 'credibility gap' and Walter Cronkite's television report

(You must also use information of your own.)

ANALYTICAL CONNECTIVES: *One decisive reason was that... • For example, this meant that... • This directly triggered... • Therefore, this was critical because... • On the other hand, another factor was... • Consequently, the ultimate result was...*

Write your response in the space provided below:

(Response continues on Page 15)

MIND-MAP MISSION Turn to Page 3 (Key Topic 3.4). Use the Consolidate Station keywords to branch out '1968 Tet Offensive Shock' and 'Nixon & Vietnamization Policy' with Walter Cronkite and phased troop withdrawals. [ ] Done

"Agent Orange & Napalm: Toxic defoliants and jellied petroleum cleared jungle canopies but devastated civilian farming communities."

QUESTION 1 PRACTICE **INFERENCE FROM SOURCE A** **4 MARKS • 5 MINS** **Score: [/ 4]**

Give two things you can infer from Source A about President Nixon's visit to US soldiers in Vietnam in 1969. [4 marks]

SOURCE A *Walter Cronkite, CBS News Special Report: Report from Vietnam (27 February 1968)*

To say that we are closer to victory today is to believe, in the face of the evidence, the optimists who have been wrong in the past. To suggest we are on the edge of defeat is to yield to unreasonable pessimism. To...

(i) What I can infer: *[1 mark]*

Details in SOURCE A that tell me this: *[1 mark]*

(ii) What I can infer: *[1 mark]*

Details in SOURCE A that tell me this: *[1 mark]*

Question 3(a): Source Utility [8 marks • 12 mins]

Study Sources B and C. How useful are Sources B and C for an enquiry into the reasons why US military tactics failed to defeat the Vietcong (1965–68)?

Target: AO3 [8 marks]: Analyse sources on Content, Contextual Knowledge, and Provenance (Nature, Origin, Purpose).

SOURCE B — Primary Evidence

"We were sent on 'search and destroy' patrols through dense jungle and steaming swamps. The strategy was simple: find the enemy, fix him, and destroy him with massive artillery and air strikes. But we could almost never locate him. The Vietcong fought on their own terms: a sudden burst of fire from concealed tree lines, a sniper round, or an explosive booby trap made from a recycled artillery shell and bamboo punji sticks. When we entered a village, we could not distinguish a friendly farmer by day from a guerrilla fighter by night. Frustrated soldiers burned thatched huts with Zippo lighters, turning the very peasants we were sent to defend into sworn enemies."

Provenance: Written by Philip Caputo, a US Marine lieutenant who commanded combat infantry units in South Vietnam in 1965–66.

SOURCE C — Primary Evidence

"The Americans possessed immense firepower—jets, helicopters, tanks, and chemical poisons that destroyed our rice crops. But they did not know the forest, and they did not know our people. Beneath the soil, we built over two hundred kilometers of multi-level tunnels with barracks, hospitals, and weapons factories. When their planes bombed, we remained safe twenty feet underground. When their infantry advanced, our booby traps—punji stakes smeared with animal dung, tripwires, and toe-poppers—inflicted daily casualties and wrecked their nerves. We were fighting for our own homeland; their soldiers fought only because they were drafted."

Provenance: Oral history interview with a veteran Vietcong combatant who operated in the Cu Chi tunnel network throughout the war.

SOURCE B UTILITY (CONTENT & COP): EYEWITNESS COMBAT OFFICER DETAILING TACTICAL FAILURES: INABILITY TO FIND THE ENEMY, BOOBY TRAPS, BURNING VILLAGES (ZIPPO RAIDS), AND LOSING THE "HEARTS AND MINDS" OF PEASANTS. *(Analyse Content, Historical Context & Provenance NOP)*

"Ho Chi Minh Trail: A 16,000km logistical highway through Laos and Cambodia supplying 60 tons of supplies daily to the South."

SOURCE C UTILITY (CONTENT & COP): PRIMARY GUERRILLA PERSPECTIVE SHOWING WHY VIETCONG TACTICS SUCCEEDED: CU CHI TUNNELS NEUTRALIZING AIR POWER, PSYCHOLOGICAL IMPACT OF BOOBY TRAPS, AND HIGH MORALE. **Score: [/ 8]**

HISTORICAL INTERPRETATIONS 1 & 2

Study Interpretations 1 and 2 below for Questions 3(b), 3(c), and 3(d)

INTERPRETATION 1

"American military tactics were fundamentally mismatched with the political realities of guerrilla warfare in Vietnam. General Westmoreland's strategy of 'search and destroy' relied on attrition—measuring progress through enemy 'body counts' rather than securing territory. Because US troops were dropped into hostile territory by helicopter and evacuated immediately after contact, they never established permanent security for South Vietnamese villagers. Furthermore, the massive reliance on indiscriminate firepower—napalm, defoliants (Agent Orange), and artillery—inflicted horrific civilian casualties, alienating the rural population and pushing thousands of previously neutral peasants into active support for the National Liberation Front."

Historian Christian G. Appy, 'Working-Class War: American Combat Soldiers and Vietnam' (1993)

INTERPRETATION 2

"The failure of the American military effort was not primarily due to flawed US tactics, but to the extraordinary effectiveness, discipline, and strategic design of the communist insurgency. The Vietcong and North Vietnamese Army operated an exceptionally sophisticated underground logistics infrastructure. Their vast network of subterranean tunnels in Cu Chi and the Iron Triangle neutralized American air superiority. Moreover, the Vietcong enforced strict discipline, utilized terror ruthlessly to eliminate uncooperative village leaders, and benefited from an inexhaustible flow of Soviet and Chinese weapons down the Ho Chi Minh Trail. The tenacity and survival techniques of the communist cadres made them impervious to military defeat."

Historian Guenter Lewy, 'America in Vietnam' (1978)

Question 3(b): Main Difference in Views [4 marks • 5 mins]

Score: [/ 4]

Study Interpretations 1 and 2. They give different views about why US military tactics failed to defeat the Vietcong. What is the main difference between these views? Explain your answer, using details from both interpretations.

Formula: Interpretation 1 argues that US failure was caused by flawed American military strategy—specifically the reliance on attrition, search-and-destroy, and indiscriminate firepower that alienated the peasant population. In contrast, Interpretation 2 argues that US failure was primarily due to the superior resilience, subterranean tunnel networks, and effective guerrilla discipline of the Vietcong.

Question 3(c): Reason Why Interpretations Differ [4 marks • 5 mins]

Score: [/ 4]

Suggest one reason why Interpretations 1 and 2 give different views about why US military tactics failed to defeat the Vietcong. You may use Sources B and C to help explain your answer.

Examiner Guidance: The historians give different views because they have utilized different perspectives in their research. The author of Interpretation 1 has focused on American combat reports and soldier accounts like Source B, emphasizing how search-and-destroy alienated Vietnamese villagers. In contrast, the author of Interpretation 2 has examined communist operational records and guerrilla testimonies like Source C, highlighting the subterranean engineering of the Cu Chi tunnels and guerrilla resilience.

QUESTION 3(D) ESSAY PLANNING & CRITERIA SETUP

16 Marks + 4 SPaG = 20 Marks • 25 Mins

How far do you agree with Interpretation 2 about the reasons why US military tactics failed to defeat the Vietcong (1965–68)?

Thesis Prompt: Establish your judgment criteria, select quotes from Interpretations 1 & 2, and deploy contextual historical knowledge.

Criteria Planning Canvas: Establish criteria benchmark, map quotes from Int 1 & Int 2, and outline your verdict: *(Essay continues on Page 19)*

Level 4 Target (13–16 Marks): Balanced analysis of both views • Sustained contextual knowledge • Justified criteria-led judgment. **SPaG: 4/4 MARKS**

Question 3(d): Evaluative Essay on Historical Interpretations

AO4: [/ 16] | SPaG: [/ 4] | Total: [/ 20]

[16 MARKS + 4 SPAG = 20 MARKS • TIMED ESSAY: 25 MINS]

How far do you agree with Interpretation 2 about the reasons why US military tactics failed to defeat the Vietcong (1965–68)?

Write your response in the space provided below:

Band 4 Criteria Check:	[ ] Criteria Established	[ ] Both Ints Explored	[ ] Precise Own Knowledge	[ ] Justified Verdict	**Teacher Sign-off:** _____

"Walter Cronkite (Feb 1968): The CBS anchor told millions of viewers that the bloody war in Vietnam was mired in an unwinnable stalemate." **19/20**

PUPIL NAME: _____ **TARGET GRADE:** ☐

#	ENQUIRY / ASSESSMENT UNIT	DO NOW (10M)	Q1 INFER (4M)	Q2 EXPLAIN (12M)	MODULE TOTAL
1	**KT3.1: Why did the US support the unpopular government of Ngo Dinh Diem in South Vietnam?** *"Why did the US support the unpopular government of Ngo Dinh Diem in South Vietnam?"* **HW Set:** _____ **Due:** _____ ☐ *Read & Quizzed* **Home Quiz:** ____/ 10 **Parent Sign:** _____	____/ 10	____/ 4	____/ 12	____/ 26
2	**KT3.2: Why did the US send combat troops to Vietnam after the Gulf of Tonkin incident?** *"Why did the US send combat troops to Vietnam after the Gulf of Tonkin incident?"* **HW Set:** _____ **Due:** _____ ☐ *Read & Quizzed* **Home Quiz:** ____/ 10 **Parent Sign:** _____	____/ 10	____/ 4	____/ 12	____/ 26
3	**KT3.3: Why did US military tactics (like bombing and search & destroy) fail to defeat the Vietcong?** *"Why did US military tactics (like bombing and search & destroy) fail to defeat the Vietcong?"* **HW Set:** _____ **Due:** _____ ☐ *Read & Quizzed* **Home Quiz:** ____/ 10 **Parent Sign:** _____	____/ 10	____/ 4	____/ 12	____/ 26
4	**KT3.4: What was Nixon's 'Vietnamization' policy, and did it achieve peace with honour?** *"What was Nixon's 'Vietnamization' policy, and did it achieve peace with honour?"* **HW Set:** _____ **Due:** _____ ☐ *Read & Quizzed* **Home Quiz:** ____/ 10 **Parent Sign:** _____	____/ 10	____/ 4	____/ 12	____/ 26
★	**Section B Capstone Assessment (pp. 16–19)** *Q3(a) Utility [8m] • Q3(b) Study Views [4m] • Q3(c) Why Differ [4m] • Q3(d) Evaluative Essay [20m]*	**Q3(a): / 8**	**Q3(b): / 4**	**Q3(c): / 4 • Q3(d): / 20**	____/ 36